

The Impact of Social Media Influencers and Content Quality Unraveling the Mediating Role of Trust on Purchase Intention

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Abstrak

In the digital landscape today, social media platforms dominate as primary channels for sharing information, shaping culture, and fostering social interaction. This study investigates the interplay between Social Media Influencer Influence, Content Quality, mediated by Trust, in shaping consumer Purchase Intentions. Using a cross-sectional quantitative design, primary data was collected through structured online questionnaires distributed via Google Docs and shared on platforms like WhatsApp, Instagram, Twitter and Facebook. Convenience sampling included 110 active social media users following influencer accounts in Indonesia and globally. Partial Least Square (PLS) analysis, facilitated by SmartPLS software, explored the relationships between variables. Results highlight the significant impact of Social Media Influencer Influence (X1) on Purchase Intentions (Y) (H1) and Content Quality (X2) on Purchase Intentions (Y) (H2), underscoring their roles in shaping consumer purchase decisions. Additionally, Social Media Influencer Influence (X1) on Trust (Z) (H3) and Content Quality (X2) on Trust (Z) (H4) emphasize their contributions to building consumer trust. Notably, Trust (Z) substantially affects Purchase Intentions (Y) (H5), reaffirming its pivotal role in shaping consumer behavior. This study provides valuable perspectives on the dynamics of influencer marketing, underscoring the significance of both Content Quality and Trust in driving Purchase Intentions. It contributes to the marketing domain by enhancing comprehension of effective influencer marketing strategies and their impact on consumers

Keywords: *Social Media Influencer, Content Quality, Trust, Purchase Intention*

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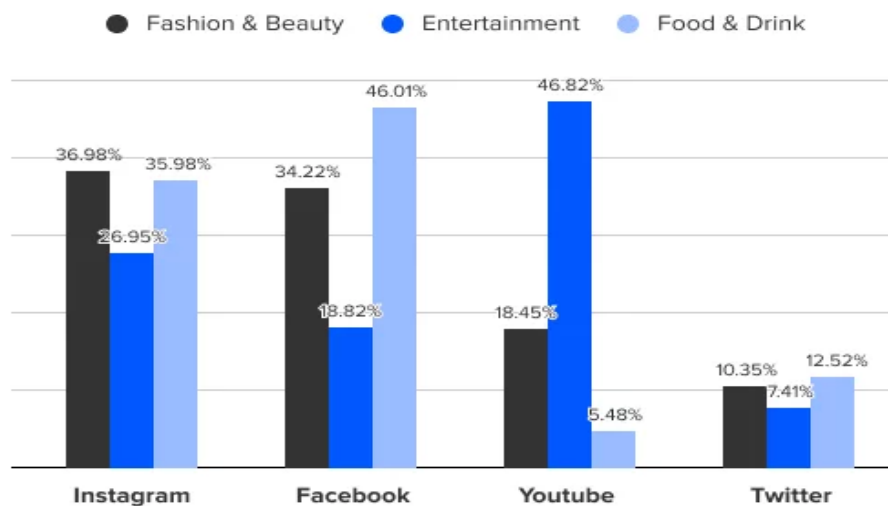
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INTRODUCTION

In the current digital era, social media has become a dominant platform for sharing information, social interaction, and cultural influence. Social media platforms have become the primary window for people to connect, communicate, and share stories on a global scale. This phenomenon has transformed the way we access news, gain insights, and expand our social networks. Amidst the widespread use of social media, Social Media Influencers have emerged as a significant force in shaping consumer behavior and purchase intentions. Previous studies have identified a positive influence of social media influencers on purchase intention (Gautam & Sharma, 2017; Chun, Cui Shan, et al, 2018; Loureiro & Sarmento, 2019; Saima & Khan, M. A, 2020). In this study, we will examine the roles of Social Media Influencers and Content Quality, mediated by Trust, in influencing purchase intention. Social Media

Influencers (SMIs) are individuals who have effectively cultivated a significant following on social networks (De Veirman et al., 2017). These SMIs embody a modern category of autonomous external endorsers, exerting influence over audience perspectives by means of their online expressions, including blogs, tweets, and other forms of social media engagement (Freberg, Karen et al., 2011). Social media influencers are individuals who possess strong influence and possess a substantial follower count on platforms such as Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, and Twitter. Through extensive utilization of social media platforms and innovative self-promotion strategies, influencers attain a position of authority and acknowledgment as opinion leaders within a devoted community of followers (Suuronen, et al., 2022). Their impact extends beyond mere engagement with their followers, to the point where brands are now enlisting them as external endorsers in influencer marketing initiatives for promoting products and services (Agrawal, A.J., 2016; Freberg, K., et al., 2011)



Source: (AnyMind, 2023)

Figure 1: Most-used Social Media Platform for the top 3 Social Media Influencer in Indonesia

Figure 1. Shows the 4 most used social media by social media influencers, and the most posted content on their social media, namely, Fashion & Beauty, Entertainment, Food and Drink. Social Media Influencer have ability to influence the opinions, preferences, and purchasing decisions of their followers. In today's modern communication landscape, Social Media Influencers (SMIs) wield substantial influence. The unique emotional connection they establish with their followers has the potential to impact how followers identify themselves, as certain followers aim to imitate the behaviors of the SMIs they are subscribed to (Tolbert & Drogos, 2019; Sánchez & Jiménez, 2021). Contemporary research endeavors have directed their attention towards investigating the impact of social media influencers as a promotional instrument within the framework of consumer decision-making (e.g., Casalo et al., 2018; Jimenez-Castillo & Sanchez-Fernandez, 2019; Ki & Kim, 2019). Given its widespread appeal, both scholars and marketing professionals are inclined to explore novel approaches for harnessing the potential of social media in promotional endeavors. Therefore, extensive research has been conducted in the fields of digital marketing, social networking, and endorsements from prominent figures (Kumar et al., 2020). In recent times, influencer

marketing has gained significant popularity due to its affordability and contemporary nature, resembling a modern form of celebrity endorsement (Hall, 2015).

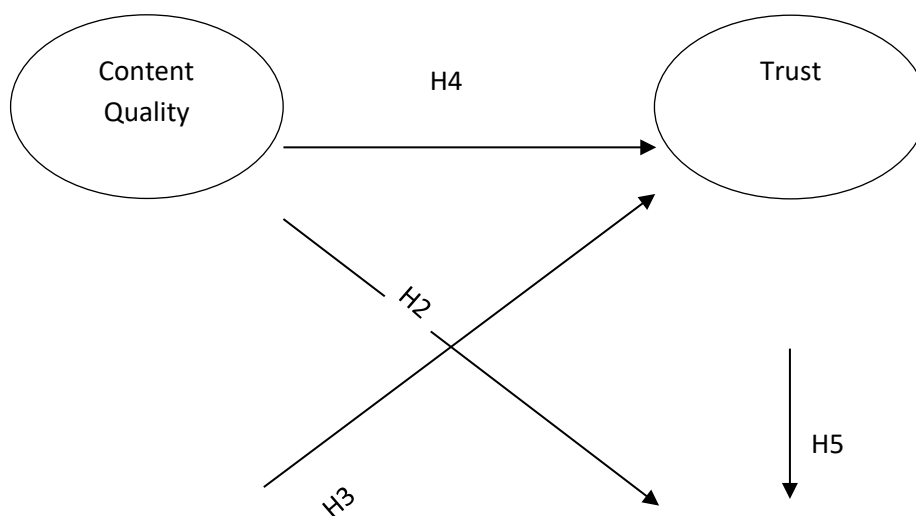
Content Quality, according to Carlson et al. (2018), Refers to the way consumers interpret the precision, comprehensiveness, pertinence, and timeliness of brand-associated details displayed on the brand's social media platform. Content Quality includes aspects such as relevant information, originality, creativity, and perceived credibility by consumers. Prior research has demonstrated that creative and captivating content exerts a favorable influence on enhancing consumer engagement and attracting their focus to a brand (Berger and Milkman, 2012). Additionally, researchers also acknowledge that content quality plays a significant role as a crucial signal in the online environment, influencing consumer behavior (O'cass and Carlson, 2012). The quality of information also exerts a crucial influence on shaping consumer choices and interactions within the digital realm (Filieri, R., 2015).

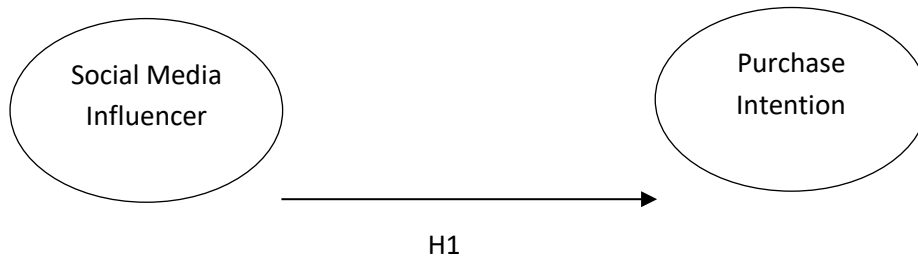
The next aspect of concern is how trust in social media influencers influences the intention to make purchases. Trust is associated with individuals' belief in others (Sun et al., 2016). In the digital realm, trust assumes a pivotal role in transactions and various other undertakings (Hajli, 2014; Sun et al., 2016). High trust levels in the online environment can create a sense of security and comfort for individuals to interact with others, share information, and conduct online transactions (Riegelsberger et al., 2005; Gefen et al., 2003). Moreover, high levels of trust can also influence consumer purchase decisions, as individuals are more likely to trust and choose brands or products recommended by others they trust (Cheung et al., 2008; Zhang et al., 2014).

Expanding on this basis, The focus of this research is to investigate the impact of Social Media Influencers and Content Quality, mediated by consumer Trust, on Purchase Intention. Through this research, we hope to provide valuable contributions to the marketing world and pave the way for more effective and relevant influencer marketing strategies for consumers.

Here is the proposed model design:

Figure 2: Research model





H1: Social Media Influencers significantly influence consumer Purchase Intentions

H2: Content Quality significantly influences Purchase Intention

H3: Sosial Media Influencer significantly influences consumer Trust

H4: Content quality significantly influences consumer trust

H5: Trust significantly influences Purchase Intention.

METHODOLOGI

This study employed a cross-sectional research design to explore the connections between various independent and dependent variables. The researchers gathered original data through online surveys distributed using Google Docs links, which were shared across popular social media platforms including WhatsApp, Instagram, and Twitter, Facebook. These surveys contained structured questions with closed-ended options and utilized a sampling approach that does not adhere to probability principles. Non-probability sampling is a sampling method where elements or participants in the population do not have an equal chance of being selected, and randomization is not considered essential in this process. Instead, the selection of sample elements from the targeted population was based on subjective judgment rather than following probabilistic principles. In this research, convenience sampling was employed due to the proximity of the research subjects to the investigator, facilitating easy access for data collection. Convenience sampling, also referred to as haphazard or accidental sampling, falls under the category of non-probability sampling methods. It involves the deliberate selection of individuals from the target population based on practical considerations like accessibility, geographical proximity, availability during specific time frames, or their willingness to engage in the study. Convenience sampling was preferred due to its simplicity, affordability, and ease of finding and involving research subjects. The study involved 110 active social media users who follow Influencers' accounts in Indonesia and worldwide. The methodology employed for data analysis in this study involves the utilization of Partial Least Squares (PLS) with the SmartPLS software tool. According to Abdilah and Jogiyanto (2015), PLS analysis is a multivariate technique that compares variables that are dependent and independent. The dependent variable (Y) implemented in this study is Purchase Intention, the independent variable (X1) is Social Media Influencer and Content Quality (X2) and the mediating variables (Intervening) are Trust (Z).

RESULT AND DISCUSSION

Respondent data

Table 1. Respondent data

No	Characteristics		Total
1	Gender	Male	40
		Female	70
2	Age	17-23	77
		24-30	16
		31-38	20

3	Education	Senior High School	14
		Bachelor	91
		Masters	7
		Doctoral	1

Source: Primary data, processed

Table 1 shows the total respondents in this study, involving a total of 110 respondents, with the highest number of female respondents in the age range of 17-23, totaling 77, and the highest number of respondents with a Bachelor's degree, which is 91.

Measurement Model Test

In line with the approach established by Hair et al. in 2017, this research utilized the techniques of evaluating convergent and discriminant validity. In the assessment of convergent validity, the model's credibility is established when the average variance extracted (AVE) exceeds the benchmark of 0.5 ($AVE > 0.5$), and the indicator for outer loading surpasses 0.7. Instances of questionnaire items failing to meet these established AVE standards were removed for each respective variable. Likewise, the discriminant validity test is considered successful when the cross-loading value on a specific variable exceeds 0.7, as stipulated by Abdillah and Jogiyanto in 2015. In terms of reliability evaluation, the study utilized the composite reliability value as a measuring tool, following the approach advocated by Hair Jr. in 2017. Variables were deemed reliable if both the composite reliability and Cronbach's Alpha value were above 0.7. The composite reliability measure offers an accurate assessment of the construct's reliability, gauging the precision of indicators and estimating the consistency of the underlying construct, as expounded by Sauddin and Ramadhani in 2018. Presented below in the table.

Table 2. Validity and Reability

	Cronbach's Alpha	Rho_A	Composite Reliability	Average Variance Extracted (AVE)
CQ	0.828	0.833	0.897	0.744
PI	0.878	0.880	0.916	0.732
SMI	0.875	0.883	0.903	0.573
T	0.892	0.892	0.926	0.757

Source: Primary data, processed

Structural Model

In this research, an exploration of the mediating variable was undertaken through a two-step process, commencing with the total effect assessment followed by the examination of the inner model, as outlined by Abdillah and Jogiyanto in 2015. The main aim of conducting the total effect test was to establish the correlation between the independent variable (X) and the dependent variable (Y). Following this, an evaluation of the inner model was performed to investigate the significance of the association between the independent and dependent variables, utilizing the methodology elucidated by Hair et al. in 2017.

Table 3. Total Effect

	Original Sample	Sample Mean	Standard Deviation	T Statistic	P Values
SMI → PI	0.394	0.398	0.108	3.663	0.000
CQ → PI	0.322	0.321	0.118	2.724	0.007

SMI → T	0.421	0.426	0.099	4.230	0.000
CQ → T	0.347	0.343	0.107	3.253	0.001
T → PI	0.390	0.392	0.096	4.053	0.000

Source: Primary data, processed

Table 3 presents the outcomes of comprehensive effect assessments concerning the interrelationships among variables. The impact of the Social Media Influencer (X1) element on Purchase Intention (Y) corroborates H1, showcasing a t-statistic measure of 3.663 and a p-value of 0.05, equivalent to 0.000. It can be deduced that Social Media Influencers (X1) exert a substantial influence on shaping consumer Purchase Intentions (Y). Likewise, the sway of Content Quality (X2) on Purchase Intention (Y) supports hypothesis 2, evidenced by a t-statistic value of 2.724 and a p-value of 0.007. This finding underscores that superior content from a Social Media Influencer (X1) can profoundly sway consumer Purchase Intention (Y). Furthermore, the research findings strongly indicate that the Social Media Influencer (X1) variable significantly impacts Consumer Trust (Z). This endorsement is strengthened by a t-statistic of 4.230 and a p-value of 0.000, substantiating the effect's non-randomness and high degree of importance. Consequently, hypothesis H3, positing the impact of the Social Media Influencer (X1) variable on Trust (Z), is validated. Similarly, Hypothesis 4, postulating the impact of Content Quality (X2) on Trust (Z), is also noteworthy. This is supported by a t-statistic of 3.253, surpassing the critical t-value threshold of 1.96, along with a p-value of 0.000. These findings underscore the substantive influence of Content Quality (X2) from Social Media Influencers on consumer Trust (Z) in the endorsed brand or product. Moreover, Table 3 additionally demonstrates that the sway of the Trust (Z) variable on Purchase Intention (Y) buttresses hypothesis 5, displaying a t-statistic of 4.053 and a p-value of 0.000 (at a 0.05 significance level). This outcome reinforces the conclusion that Trust (Z) plays a meaningful role in shaping consumer Purchase Intentions (Y).

Table 4. R Square

	R Square
Purchase Intention	0.519
Trust	0.511

Table 4 illustrates the impact of the independent variable on the other variables. The R² values for the variables Purchase Intention and Trust are 0.519 and 0.511. This means that Social Media influencer and content quality influence both variables by 51.9% and 51.1%.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, the current digital era has witnessed the ascendancy of social media as a dominant platform for global information sharing, social interactions, and cultural influence. Within this context, social media influencers have emerged as formidable forces in shaping consumer behavior and purchase intentions. Past research has emphasized the beneficial effects of social media influencers on purchase intentions, providing the foundation for the current study. This study aimed to examine the interplay of Social Media Influencers and Content Quality, mediated by Consumer Trust, in influencing consumer purchase intentions. The findings of this study shed light on several key insights:

1. **Social Media Influencers' Impact:** The analysis revealed that Social Media Influencers significantly influence consumer Purchase Intentions. Their substantial follower base and innovative self-promotion strategies position them as opinion leaders, exerting a profound impact beyond mere follower interaction.

2. **Content Quality's Significance:** Content Quality also played a pivotal role, significantly influencing Purchase Intentions. High-quality content from Social Media Influencers emerged as a potent catalyst in swaying consumer purchase decisions, capturing their attention and fostering positive interactions.
3. **Consumer Trust as a Mediator:** Consumer Trust was identified as a crucial mediator in this relationship. The study established that the Social Media Influencer variable significantly influences Consumer Trust. Trust, in turn, significantly influences Purchase Intentions, underscoring the pivotal role trust plays in shaping consumer behavior.
4. **Dual Role of Content Quality:** Content Quality emerged as a dual influencer. Not only did it significantly influence Consumer Trust, as mediated by Content Quality, but it also directly impacted Purchase Intentions. This highlights the multi-faceted impact of compelling and credible content.

Overall, this research substantiates the central role of Social Media Influencers and Content Quality in shaping consumer purchase intentions, with Consumer Trust serving as a crucial intermediary. The findings underscore the importance of fostering authentic and trust-based relationships between influencers and their followers, as well as the significance of delivering high-quality content that resonates with consumers. In the realm of marketing, this study offers valuable insights into developing effective influencer-driven strategies that align with modern consumer preferences and behaviors. As the digital landscape continues to evolve, understanding these dynamics is essential for brands seeking to navigate and harness the potency of influencer marketing to drive consumer engagement and purchase decisions.

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